

KF Mini-Meeting Lesson 6

--"MINI-MEETING" FORMAT-- (20 min)

I - MINDFULNESS (4 min)

-ANB (1 min)

-3 Minute Breathing Space (3 min)

II - CHECK-IN (10 min)

-KF Member "A" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

-KF Member "B" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

III - KF MEETING "PREVIEW" (6 min)

-Bible Teaching -- selected excerpt of upcoming KF Bible teaching (5 min)

-Ending Prayer (1 min)

BIBLE TEACHING

Let's return to the first chapter of James. Hopefully, you have printed this chapter out and have it in front of you. We will review what we have learned in the last few meetings and then consider what agape love looks like for Christians.

Our text for this lesson is **James 1:2–4**. These verses have been translated by Nancy.

²Guide yourselves into all joy, my siblings, when you fall into and are surrounded by all kinds of experiments, ³ knowing that the examination of what you truly trust and act upon results in the ability to remain under examination as it explores your ever-expanding potential. ⁴Give this growing ability of endurance a chance to accomplish its purpose, which is to make you a mature and complete person, lacking nothing, fully equipped for your joy and mission.

Take a deep breath.

1. **The struggle is the valuable part of our process**

It is only in the struggle that we develop endurance and courage. Endurance without judgment gives us the creative space we need to learn how to build a glorious life and a karis relationship with God. It is, however, not productive to struggle against people or against the Creation; our struggle is with our Idol Self. Immanuel Kant, who is considered to be the father of modern philosophy, taught that *struggle is the indispensable accompaniment of progress*. (Repeat) Let's learn to struggle well.

2. **The discovery and fostering of our True Self takes a lot of endurance**

Any kind of growth requires a sustained effort in a consistent direction. That takes courage. For example, Karis Fellowships itself is the result of courageous sustained effort over decades. Without the courage and endurance of several people, we would not be here. As you begin to discover your True Self, you will feel fear because you are going into the not-knowing and abandoning your search for glory. If something goes wrong, if the path isn't easy, or if you are uncomfortable—and you feel that fear again – you will need courage to withstand the temptation to return to your old patterns of reacting. You will also need courage to endure your self-hate long enough to manage it productively, first by recognizing that you are in self-hate and then by using your KF tools. Your tools will help you hold your course rather than escaping into compulsive addictive behaviors or imposing frantic claims on others and on life.

3. **Let endurance have its perfect result**

What is endurance? The Greek word translated as *endurance* means to *remain under*. It means to resist running away. Running away looks different for different Idol types. A mastery type runs away by taking control or attacking. A self-effacing type runs away by appeasing and complying. A resigned type just runs. It takes faith, or trust, to stand and resist running away. We learn that productive endurance is *for* us; it plays a crucial part in developing our True Self and revealing our real glory. Most of us were not trained to endure productively. We endured only to support the agenda of the people around us or to indulge their comfort—in other words, to pacify their Idol Self. This kind of endurance was not about developing our potential but about satisfying someone else's compulsive needs. We suffered without any benefit to ourselves. Now, however, we have the tools to/tools that make endurance beneficial and profitable, not only for ourselves but also for this world.

Let's switch gears a little and look at an aspect of agape love that is similar to endurance. The passage that describes Christian agape is found in First Corinthians, chapter 13. Firstly, love is *macrothumos*. That is the Greek word for this quality. Macrothumos is listed first because without it the other qualities of love are impossible. Macrothumos means *long-tempered* as opposed to *short-tempered*. It is sometimes translated as *long-suffering*. When you choose long-suffering, however, you are not choosing to just suffer for a long time. Macrothumos is strategic. It has a purpose in view and can use your discomfort to achieve that purpose.

You are learning to welcome the way that life runs all kinds of experiments on you. God uses these trials as opportunities to reveal where your trust lies. Ultimately, your goal is to learn to be long-tempered—to refuse the easy path of giving in to your tensions; to resist running away; and, instead, to be strategic in thought, word, and action, no matter how you feel. When your True Self is connected to the Holy Spirit, you can trust God when others are panicking, snatching, controlling, or hysterical. You know what that looks like—going out of control to get control. It is fear, once again, paralyzing people and driving them to mindlessly manipulate or attack.

Why must we learn to love? Because, as we learned in First John, love casts out all fear. Do you want to cast out your fear? In Karis Fellowships, we are learning to be people of no fear who are becoming the love of God in this sorry world.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, help me to let Your love cast out my fear. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank you for this time together of healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.